

The Value of Public Libraries

Public libraries are among the few remaining institutions that welcome everyone without asking for anything in return. They lend books, of course, but they also provide internet access, quiet study spaces, children's programs, job-search help and a place to be warm in winter. In many towns the library is the only public building open on a Saturday afternoon.

Critics sometimes argue that the internet has made libraries obsolete. The opposite is true. As information has become abundant, the skills of evaluating it have become scarce, and librarians are trained precisely in those skills. A good reference librarian can save a student days of confused searching.

Funding, however, remains fragile. Library budgets are often the first to be trimmed when a city council needs savings, because the damage is slow and invisible. Yet the cost of a library is tiny compared with the value it creates for the people who rely on it most.